

49 Jael

The Kenite woman who killed Sisera in her tent and fulfilled Deborah's word.

Jael was the wife of Heber the Kenite, a man from the clan of Moses' in-laws who had moved north and pitched his tent near Kedesh. Heber's household was at peace with Jabin king of Canaan. So when Jabin's general Sisera fled on foot from Barak's army, he ran to Jael's tent, expecting safety. She invited him in, covered him, and gave him milk when he asked for water. When he fell asleep, she drove a tent peg through his temples. Deborah had said that the LORD would sell Sisera into the hand of a woman, and Jael was that woman. Deborah's song calls her "blessed above women," though readers still wrestle with how she broke the rules of hospitality.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Yael</i> , "mountain goat" or "wild goat"
Family	Wife of Heber the Kenite (Judges 4:17)
People	The Kenites, descended from Hobab, Moses' father-in-law (Judges 4:11)
When	In the days of Deborah and Barak. Any BC date is rough
Key places	Her tent near the plain of Zaanaim, by Kedesh (Judges 4:11)
Key people	Sisera, Barak, Deborah, Heber
Main passages	Judges 4:11, 17–22; 5:6, 24–27
New Testament	Not named

"Blessed above women shall Jael the wife of Heber the Kenite be, blessed shall she be above women in the tent."

Judges 5:24, KJV

The life of Jael

Judges gives no calendar dates. On the early chronology the judges span c. 1375–1050 BC, but any single date for Jael is rough. Her whole story takes place in a single day.

Before the battle	● Living near Kedesh Heber has separated from the other Kenites and pitched his tent near Kedesh. His house is at peace with Jabin. <i>Judges 4:11, 17</i>
The day of the battle	● Welcomes Sisera Sisera flees on foot to her tent. She goes out to meet him and says, "Turn in, my lord, turn in to me; fear not." She covers him with a mantle. <i>Judges 4:17–18</i>
In the tent	● Gives him milk He asks for a little water, and she opens a bottle of milk and covers him again. He tells her to stand at the door and turn away anyone who asks. <i>Judges 4:19–20</i>
While he sleeps	● Kills Sisera She takes a tent peg and a hammer, goes softly to him, and drives the peg through his temples into the ground. <i>Judges 4:21</i>
When Barak arrives	● Shows him Sisera She goes out to meet Barak and says, "Come, and I will shew thee the man whom thou seekest." <i>Judges 4:22</i>

Group notes

Key activities

Christians have judged Jael in different ways. Some see her as a brave woman who sided with God's people at great risk. Others are troubled that she broke the customs of hospitality. The text itself praises her in Deborah's song and does not comment further.

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- 1 Went out to meet Sisera.** She took the first step and invited him in.
Judges 4:18
 - 2 Covered him.** She hid him under a mantle in her tent. *Judges 4:18*
 - 3 Gave more than he asked.** "He asked water, and she gave him milk; she brought forth butter in a lordly dish." *Judges 5:25*
 - 4 Struck the enemy.** She "took a nail of the tent, and took an hammer in her hand," and killed him as he slept. *Judges 4:21; 5:26-27*
 - 5 Showed Barak.** She met the pursuing commander at her door and led him to Sisera's body. *Judges 4:22*
 - 6 Fulfilled prophecy.** Deborah had said, "the LORD shall sell Sisera into the hand of a woman." *Judges 4:9*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Jael.

Old Testament

Judges 4:17–22	This is the main account.
Judges 5:6	Deborah's song dates hard times to "the days of Jael," when highways were empty.
Judges 5:24–27	The song blesses Jael and retells Sisera's death in poetry.
Echoes	Another woman ends a battle by striking a leader's head: at Thebez a woman drops a millstone on Abimelech (Judges 9:53). Some Christian readers link the crushing of the enemy's head with the promise in Genesis 3:15.

New Testament

Echoes	Elisabeth greets Mary with similar words: "Blessed art thou among women" (Luke 1:42). Hebrews 11:34 speaks of those who "out of weakness were made strong" and "turned to flight the armies of the aliens."
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For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Sisera ask for, and what did Jael give him (Judges 4:19; 5:25)?
2. *Understand:* Heber's house was at peace with Jabin. What might it have cost Jael to take Israel's side?
3. *Apply:* Jael acted with what was in her tent. What ordinary tools, skills or places has God given you to serve him?
4. *Apply:* Her story leaves hard questions. How can your group honour Scripture while talking honestly about passages that trouble you?